

Patterns in Play — Module 08: Planning — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. What is the difference between just playing and planning a game? (Planning adds intention and structure).
2. Why are treasure hunts so exciting? (You follow a plan of clues to reach a goal — like an adventure!).
3. What does a game designer have to think about? (Rules, fun, fairness, challenge, surprise).
4. Why is testing your game important? (You find out what works and what needs fixing).
5. What is the best game you have ever played? What made it great?
6. How do you plan a birthday party? (Invitations, food, games, decorations — so many steps!).
7. Why do some plans fail? (Because the real world surprises us — and that is okay!).
8. What is more important: the plan or the willingness to change the plan?
9. How far ahead do you think when you play chess or checkers? (One move? Three moves?).
10. If you could design any game in the world, what would it be?

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Design a treasure hunt for your family: Write 5 clues, each leading to the next. Hide a small prize at the end. Did the hunters follow the plan you imagined?
2. Invent a brand new board game. Draw the board, write the rules, decide the goal. Play it together. What needs to be fixed?
3. Plan a "Family Game Night" from start to finish: Choose games, prepare snacks, set a schedule. Follow the plan and see how it goes.
4. Take an existing game and redesign one rule. Play with the new rule. Is it better or worse? Why? Game design is iterative — test, learn, improve.

5. Draw a map of an imaginary world. Add challenges, treasures, and characters. This is game design through world-building!
6. Plan a 10-minute outdoor activity for the family. Include: What, Where, When, What we need. Then do it! How well did the plan work?
7. Create a "Game Design Journal." After each game you play this week, write: What I liked, What I would change, My game idea inspired by it.
8. Build a marble run, domino chain, or Rube Goldberg machine. This requires planning each step so the chain reaction works. Test and improve!
9. Design a "Mystery Dinner": Plan a meal where each family member gets a different, secret task. Come together and see if the plan produces a full meal!
10. At the end of the day, reflect: What plans did you make today? Which ones worked? Which ones surprised you? Planning is a skill that gets better with practice, just like playing.